way; conservation of energy also only works if we multiply the energy of each branch by its associated weight.

It makes sense, then, that we should do the same with utility. If we have a universe with some given total utility, and we measure a spin to branch it in two, the post-branching utility should be the sum of the weights of each branch times their utilities. Then, in the likely event that our spin measurement didn't affect anyone's utility in a substantial way, the total utility is completely unchanged by our measurement. That's just what our intuition might expect. It's also what we would directly conclude from the decision-theoretic approach to probability we mentioned in Chapter Six. From this perspective, Many-Worlds shouldn't change our ideas about moral action in any noticeable way.

It's nevertheless possible to cook up a system in which the difference between Many-Worlds and collapse theories really would be morally relevant. Imagine that some quantum experiment will lead to equally likely outcomes A or B, with A being extremely good and B being just a little bit good, and that these effects apply to everyone in the world with equal measure. In a single-world view, a utilitarian (or any commonsensical person, really) would be in favor of running the experiment, since either the vast good of A or the minor good of B would raise the net utility of the world. But imagine that your ethical code is entirely devoted to equality: you don't care what happens, as long as it happens to everyone equally. On the collapse theory, you don't know which outcome will happen, but either one maintains equality, so it's still a good idea to run the experiment. But in Many-Worlds, people in one branch will experience A while those on the other branch will experience B. Even if the branches can't communicate or otherwise interact, this could conceivably offend your moral sensibilities, so you'd be against doing the experiment at all. Personally I don't think that inequality between people who literally live in different worlds should matter that much to us, but the logical possibility is there.

Excluding such artificial constructions, Many-Worlds doesn't seem to have many moral implications. The picture of branching as "creating" an entirely new copy of the universe is a vivid one, but not quite right. It's better to think of it as dividing the existing universe into almost-identical slices, each one of which has a smaller weight than the original. If we follow that picture carefully, we conclude that it's correct to think about our future exactly as if we lived in a single stochastic universe that obeyed the